

SEID 2364 – Assignment 12 Final Case Study Specification Draft

Part 1 – Case Selected

Selected Case Study: COVID-19 Misinformation Moderation

This case study focuses on how social media platforms moderated misinformation during the COVID-19 pandemic. Platforms removed, labeled, or reduced the visibility of misleading claims related to vaccines, masks, treatments, and public-health restrictions.

The system matters ethically because moderation decisions affected public health, access to information, freedom of expression, and public trust in institutions.

Part 2 – System Goal

The system claims to reduce harmful misinformation and protect public health. Platforms aimed to prevent the spread of false medical information that could increase harm during the pandemic.

However, the system goal is partly contested because some users believed moderation protected society, while others viewed it as censorship or excessive control over public discourse.

Part 3 – Agents / Players

1. Social Media Platforms Platforms such as Facebook, YouTube, and X designed and enforced moderation systems.
2. Public-Health Authorities Health organizations and experts provided guidance about misinformation trends and harmful claims.
3. Users Users created, shared, consumed, or challenged information on online platforms.
4. Governments and Regulators Governments influenced policy discussions and sometimes pressured platforms to take stronger moderation action.

Part 4 – Player Goals and Victory Conditions

Social Media Platforms Goal: Reduce harmful misinformation while maintaining user engagement.

Victory Condition: Platforms successfully limit harmful content without losing public trust or users.

Public-Health Authorities Goal: Protect public health and reduce dangerous misinformation.

Victory Condition: Users follow accurate medical guidance and harmful false claims are minimized.

Users Goal: Access and share information freely.

Victory Condition: Users can participate in discussion without unfair censorship or misinformation.

Conflict exists because reducing misinformation may require restricting some forms of speech, creating tension between public safety and freedom of expression.

Part 5 – Signals and Signal Powers

Major signals include posts, labels, warnings, fact-checks, moderation decisions, and public-health announcements.

Platforms can amplify or suppress signals through recommendation algorithms and moderation systems. Fact-checkers and health authorities can verify information, while users can reinterpret or challenge signals.

Signal control matters ethically because platforms influence what information becomes visible, trusted, or hidden during a crisis.

Part 6 – Rules, Constraints, and Meta-Game

Internal rules include platform moderation policies, community standards, and algorithmic ranking systems.

The meta-game includes government pressure, public opinion, media attention, legal regulation, and economic incentives. Public trust and political debate strongly shaped how moderation systems operated during the pandemic.

Part 7 – Information and Observability

Platforms and developers had high observability because they could monitor trends, user behavior, and moderation outcomes.

Users had much lower observability because they often could not fully understand why content was removed or downranked.

Governments and regulators had partial observability depending on cooperation from platforms.

This creates asymmetry because power over information visibility becomes concentrated within platforms and institutions.

Part 8 – EDOCA Diagnosis

Effort: Moderating misinformation required large amounts of computational resources, human moderators, and fact-checking systems.

Distortion: Information could become distorted when moderation systems incorrectly classified scientific debate or removed legitimate discussion.

Observability: Platforms could observe moderation systems internally, while ordinary users had limited visibility into decision-making.

Control: Platforms controlled recommendation systems, moderation tools, and information visibility.

Authority: Governments and public-health institutions influenced moderation policies, while platforms enforced operational decisions.

The framework highlights ethical problems involving uneven control, limited transparency, and concentrated authority over information.

Part 9 – Ethical Instability

The system becomes ethically unstable when platforms attempt to reduce misinformation while simultaneously controlling public discourse. Platforms may achieve the local goal of reducing harmful content but also create broader concerns about censorship, transparency, and institutional trust.

The instability is structural because authority, observability, and control are concentrated within a small number of powerful organizations.

Part 10 – Evidence Plan

1. COVID-19 misinformation case study This source provides factual context about moderation strategies and public-health concerns.
2. ACM Code of Ethics This source supports analysis of professional responsibilities related to computing systems and moderation practices.
3. IEEE Code of Ethics This source provides guidance about engineering responsibility, public welfare, and technical accountability.
4. EU AI Act resources These sources help explain governance, transparency, and regulatory approaches connected to digital systems and AI moderation.

Conclusion

This assignment helped structure the ethical system surrounding COVID-19 misinformation moderation. The case involves multiple agents, competing goals, information asymmetry, and concentrated authority over digital communication.

The analysis shows that ethical instability emerges not simply from individual decisions but from the broader structure of the socio-technical system itself.